

B2.4.2.3 Intonation, Cadence, and Phonetic Variations in Bolivia — Practice

Part 1: True or False

1. Highland (Andean) Bolivian Spanish and lowland Bolivian Spanish sound identical.
2. Highland Spanish tends to have a more clipped, measured rhythm.
3. Lowland Spanish, spoken around Santa Cruz, has a faster, more melodic quality.
4. A final "-s" is more likely to soften or drop in highland speech than in lowland speech.
5. Regional accent differences in Bolivian Spanish are considered pronunciation "errors."

Part 2: Short Answer

1. Name the two broad Bolivian dialect regions discussed in this lesson.
2. Which two indigenous languages have influenced highland Bolivian Spanish rhythm?
3. What happens to a final "-s" in parts of lowland Bolivian speech?
4. Why shouldn't you treat a regional accent as something to "correct"?

Part 3: Application

For each phrase, identify whether it more likely reflects highland or lowland pronunciation habits, and explain why in one sentence.

1. A speaker pronounces every syllable of "los estudiantes están listos" clearly, including each final -s.
2. A speaker says "¿vamos a la fiesta?" with a fast, melodic, sing-song rhythm.

Answer Key

Part 1: True or False

1. False
2. True
3. True
4. False (final -s softens more in lowland speech, stays clearer in highland speech)
5. False

Part 2: Short Answer

1. The Andean highlands (La Paz, Oruro, Potosí) and the eastern lowlands (Santa Cruz, Beni).
2. Quechua and Aymara.
3. It can soften or drop, similar to patterns in coastal/lowland Spanish elsewhere in Latin America.
4. Because accent variation is a normal feature of any widely-spoken language, not a mistake — like a regional accent in English.

Part 3: Application

1. Highland — the clear, evenly-stressed pronunciation of each syllable, including the final -s, is typical of highland speech.
2. Lowland — the fast, melodic, sing-song rhythm is typical of lowland speech around Santa Cruz.